



MONGOLIA

Capital city: Ulan Bator
Area: 604,247 sq miles (1,565,000 sq km)
Population: 2,600,000
Official language: Khalkh Mongol
Major religions: Buddhist 96%, Muslim 4%
Government: Multiparty democracy
Currency: Tughrik
Adult literacy rate: 98%
Life expectancy: 65 years
People per doctor: 366
Televisions: 63 per 1,000 people

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THE REMOTE, SPARSELY POPULATED country of Mongolia was once the center of a vast empire. For most of the 20th century, however, Mongolia was a communist country linked to Soviet Russia until democratic rule was introduced in 1990. Many people live on the grassy plains in the center of the country, tending their flocks as they move in search of new pasture. The climate is harsh – summers are short, winters are long and cold. Mountain ranges ring the country to the north and west, while the south is bordered by the Gobi Desert. The country is rich in natural resources, with huge deposits of coal and oil, but it is only recently that these have been developed.



GENGHIS KHAN

During the 13th century, the Mongol leader Genghis Khan carved out a huge empire that stretched across much of central Asia and China. By the time of his death, it was said that it took almost a year to ride from one side of his empire to the other. His grandson, Kublai Khan, became emperor of China, but the Mongol empire fell apart during the 1300s.



The framework of a yurt consists of a circular latticework frame with a central ring to support the roof. The frame is covered with felt lashed together with rope.



Smoke from the iron stove escapes through a chimney in the roof of the yurt.

A yurt may have as many as eight layers of felt to keep out the winter cold.

Flaps may be drawn over the single wooden or felt door.

NOMADIC LIFE

The nomadic farmers of Mongolia move with their yaks, sheep, goats, camels, and cattle from the summertime pastures high in the mountains down to the grassy lowland steppes during the winter months. Yaks are ideally suited to the harsh Mongolian climate and provide milk, butter, meat, and wool. As the nomads move with their flocks, they take their portable dome-shaped yurts with them.



HORSE RIDERS

Many Mongols are accomplished horse riders. From a very early age, Mongolian children learn to ride horses, becoming jockeys at the age of as little as three. Every July 11 they get the chance to show off their skills at the Nadam Festival, a nationwide sporting event that includes horse racing, archery, and wrestling competitions.

ULAN BATOR

The capital city of Mongolia lies at the center of road and rail networks in the country. Until the 1920s Ulan Bator was a small country town, but development by its communist rulers has turned it into a major city. The influence of Soviet Russia is reflected in the style of many of the city's major buildings.



MAKING MUSIC

Mongol nomads like to entertain themselves in the evening with music. Stringed instruments, such as the Mongolian fiddle, are popular.

Find out more

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